

Social Stratification: An Introduction

A descriptive account of structured inequality — its definitions, characteristics, historical forms, and sociological significance

Definition

The systematic ranking of individuals and groups along a hierarchy of unequal access to scarce and valued resources

Characteristics

Universal, ancient, socially constructed, consequential for life chances, and transmitted across generations

Forms

Slavery, Caste, Estate, Class, Gender, and Racial & Ethnic Stratification

Introduction

The Central Question

Human societies, throughout history, have rarely been organized as collections of equals. From the smallest tribal band to the largest industrial nation, people are ranked, graded, and arranged into layers based on the resources they possess, the roles they occupy, and the value society attaches to them.

This structured pattern of inequality — enduring, socially patterned, and passed on from one generation to the next — is what sociologists call **social stratification**.

Why It Matters

Understanding stratification is central to sociology because it explains not only **who gets what**, but why some individuals and groups consistently get more than others, and how such arrangements are justified, reproduced, and occasionally overturned.

Scope of This lecture

This lecture presents a descriptive account of the concept of social stratification, its defining characteristics, its major historical and contemporary forms, the principal sociological theories that attempt to explain it, and the closely related concept of **social mobility** — the movement of individuals or groups within or between strata.

2. Definition of Social Stratification

The term "stratification" is borrowed from geology, where it refers to rock layers (*strata*) formed over time and arranged one above another. Sociologists use the term metaphorically to describe the layering of society into a hierarchy of social positions, each associated with differing amounts of **wealth, power, and prestige**.

Pitirim Sorokin, *Social Mobility* (1927)

"Social stratification is the differentiation of a given population into hierarchically superposed classes... it is manifested in the existence of upper and lower social layers."

Melvin M. Tumin, *Social Stratification* (1967)

"Social stratification refers to the arrangement of any social group or society into a hierarchy of positions that are unequal with regard to power, property, social evaluation, and psychic gratification."

Raymond W. Murray, *Introductory Sociology* (1983)

"Social stratification is a horizontal division of society into higher and lower social units."

Anthony Giddens, *Sociology* (2009)

"Stratification can be defined as structured inequalities between different groupings of people... best conceptualized as a system of layers."

3. Characteristics of Social Stratification

Social, not merely biological or individual

Differences such as age, sex, or physical strength only become stratification when society assigns unequal social value and rewards to them (Haralambos & Holborn).

Ancient in origin

Stratification is traceable to the earliest recorded human societies, evolving from simple age- and gender-based ranking to complex class systems.

Consequential for life chances

A person's position affects access to education, healthcare, employment, marriage partners, and even life expectancy and treatment before the law.

Universal

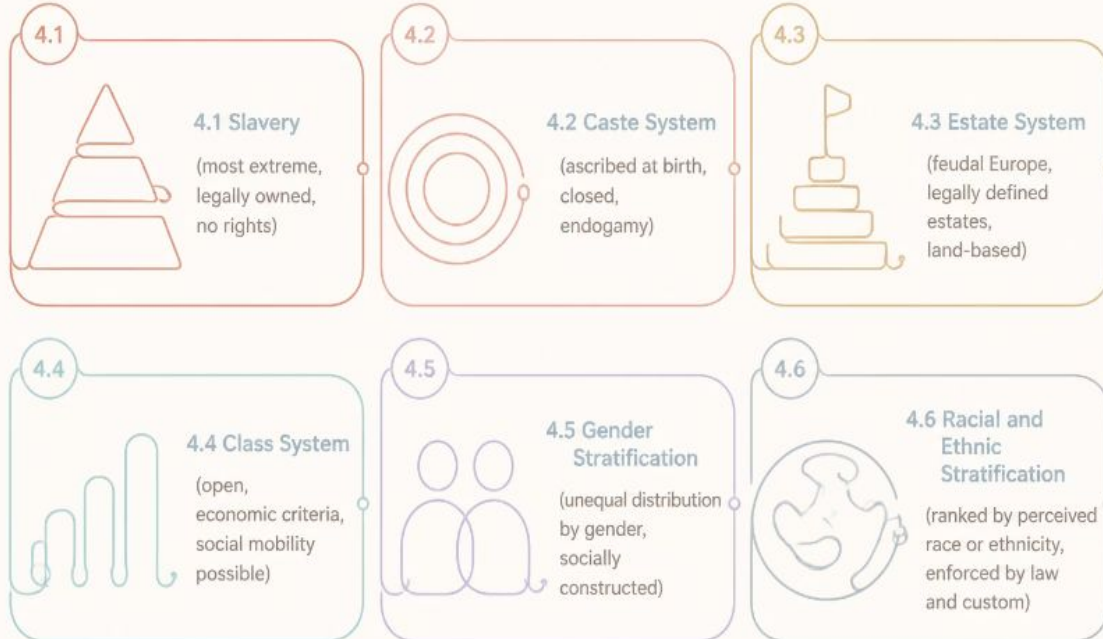
Some degree of stratification has been observed in virtually every known society, ancient and modern, though its intensity and basis vary widely.

Social in nature and diverse in form

It appears differently across cultures and periods — as slavery, caste, estate, or class — depending on the values a society upholds.

4. Types (Forms) of Social Stratification

Sociologists have identified six principal forms of social stratification, ranging from the most rigid and closed systems to more open and fluid arrangements found in modern societies.



Each form differs in its degree of openness, the criteria used to assign rank, and the extent to which individuals can move between strata. The sections that follow examine each type in detail.

Slavery

Defining Features

Legal Ownership

One human being is legally owned as the property of another

No Personal Rights

The enslaved person has virtually no personal rights or legal standing

Fixed Involuntary

Status is fixed, involuntary, and typically inherited

Overview

Slavery is the **most extreme and rigid form of stratification**, in which one human being is legally owned as the property of another and has virtually no personal rights. It was widespread in ancient Greece and Rome, and in the plantation economies of the Americas prior to abolition in the nineteenth century.

Characteristics

- Status under slavery is **fixed** — there is no legitimate pathway to change one's position
- Membership is **involuntary** — imposed through conquest, birth, or debt
- Status is **typically inherited** — children of enslaved persons were themselves enslaved
- Historical examples include ancient Greece, Rome, and pre-abolition plantation economies of the Americas

Caste System

The caste system is a **closed and rigid form of stratification** in which status is entirely ascribed at birth and cannot be changed during an individual's lifetime. It is most closely associated with traditional Hindu society in India.

Shudras

Laborers and servants; the lowest of the four varnas

Vaishyas

Traders and merchants; the third varna

Kshatriyas

Warriors and rulers; the second varna

Brahmins

Priests and scholars; the highest varna



Caste membership determines occupation, is enforced through endogamy (marriage within the caste), and restricts social interaction such as dining and physical contact across caste lines. A group historically treated as outside the caste hierarchy altogether also existed alongside the four varnas.

Estate System

The estate (or feudal) system characterized **medieval Europe** and divided society into legally defined estates, each holding distinct rights, obligations, and relationships to land.



The Nobility

Held land and political authority; obligations included military service and governance



The Clergy

Administered religious life; offered a rare pathway for upward movement from lower estates



The Commoners

Peasants and serfs; bound to the land and obligated to provide labor and tribute

Comparison with Caste

Unlike the caste system, movement between estates — though **difficult** — was not entirely impossible. The Church and military service provided limited channels for upward mobility, distinguishing the estate system from the absolute closure of caste.

Basis of Rank

Rank in the estate system was grounded in **legally defined rights and obligations** tied to land ownership and hereditary title, rather than purely economic criteria as in the modern class system.

Class System

Overview

The class system is an **open form of stratification** found in modern industrial and capitalist societies, based primarily on economic criteria — income, occupation, and property ownership — rather than birth alone. Unlike caste or estate systems, class membership is, in principle, **achieved rather than solely ascribed**, and social mobility (movement between classes) is possible through education, occupational achievement, or marriage.

Criteria for Class Position

- **Income** — wages, salaries, and returns on investment
- **Occupation** — the nature and prestige of one's work
- **Property ownership** — ownership of productive assets and wealth

Theoretical Perspectives

Max Weber and Karl Marx both offered influential, though differing, analyses of class:

Karl Marx

Emphasized ownership of the means of production as the defining criterion; identified bourgeoisie and proletariat as the two fundamental classes

Max Weber

Proposed a multidimensional view incorporating class (economic), status (social honor), and party (political power) as distinct but related dimensions of stratification

Gender Stratification

Gender stratification refers to the **unequal distribution of wealth, power, and privilege between men and women**, rooted in socially constructed roles and expectations rather than biological difference alone.



Unequal Distribution

Wealth, power, and privilege are distributed unequally between men and women across virtually all known societies, manifesting in income gaps, occupational segregation, and differential access to political authority.



Socially Constructed

The inequalities are rooted in **socially constructed roles and expectations** — norms about appropriate behavior, labor, and status assigned on the basis of gender — rather than in biological difference alone.



Structural in Character

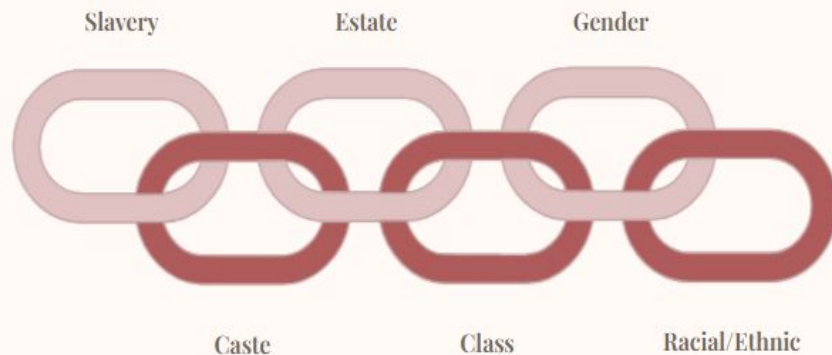
Like other forms of stratification, gender stratification is systematic and persistent, embedded in institutions such as the family, the labor market, the legal system, and cultural norms.

Racial and Ethnic Stratification

Racial or ethnic stratification ranks groups according to **perceived racial or ethnic characteristics**, often reinforced through law and custom. It represents one of the most consequential and historically documented forms of structured inequality.

Mechanisms of Enforcement

- Legal codification of racial categories and differential rights
- Social customs restricting interaction, residence, and opportunity across racial lines
- Institutional practices that reproduce racial hierarchies across generations



Theories of Social Stratification

Functionalist Theory

Davis & Moore (1945)

1

Weberian Theory

Multidimensional

3

Lenski's Synthesis

Evolutionary

5

Conflict Theory

Karl Marx

2

Symbolic Interactionism

Micro-level

4

Social Mobility

Types & Factors

6

Theories of Social Stratification

Social stratification — the hierarchical arrangement of individuals and groups in society — has been explained through several competing theoretical traditions. Each tradition asks a different question: *Why does inequality exist? Who benefits? How is it maintained? And does it change over time?*

Functionalist Theory

Stratification as a universal necessity ensuring qualified individuals fill important roles (Davis & Moore, 1945).

Conflict Theory

Stratification as a product of class conflict rooted in ownership of the means of production (Marx).

Weberian Theory

Stratification as multidimensional — class, status, and party — not reducible to economics alone (Weber).

Symbolic Interactionism

Stratification expressed and reproduced through everyday symbols, consumption, and face-to-face interaction (Veblen).

Lenski's Synthesis

Degree of inequality tied to a society's mode of subsistence and level of technological development (Lenski, 1966).

1. Functionalist Theory (Davis and Moore)

Core Argument

Kingsley Davis and Wilbert Moore, in their influential 1945 article "Some Principles of Stratification" (*American Sociological Review*), argued that stratification is a **universal necessity** that exists in every society because it serves an important function: ensuring that the most functionally important social positions are filled by the most qualified people.

Since some positions (such as physicians or engineers) require scarce talent and lengthy, costly training, society must offer greater rewards — income, prestige, and power — to motivate capable individuals to undergo the necessary sacrifice. Inequality, in this functionalist view, is therefore both **inevitable and beneficial**, as it motivates individuals to strive for socially useful roles.

Reference: Davis, K., & Moore, W. E. (1945). Some Principles of Stratification. *American Sociological Review*, 10(2), 242–249.

Tumin's Critique (1953)

This theory was strongly criticized by Melvin Tumin (1953), who raised three principal objections:

- It is difficult to **objectively measure** the "functional importance" of a position.
- **Talent is not necessarily scarce** — the assumption of scarcity is unproven.
- Stratification often **restricts rather than promotes** the discovery of talent by limiting opportunities available to those born into lower strata.

Reference: Tumin, M. M. (1953). Some Principles of Stratification: A Critical Analysis. *American Sociological Review*, 18(4), 387–394.

2. Conflict Theory (Karl Marx)

Karl Marx located the origin of stratification in the **economic structure of society**, specifically in the relationship of individuals to the means of production (land, factories, capital).

The Bourgeoisie

Own the means of production. Extract **surplus value** from the labor of the proletariat, producing an inherently exploitative and conflictual relationship between the classes.

The Proletariat

Must sell their labor power to survive. Subject to exploitation under the capitalist mode of production, with no ownership stake in the fruits of their labor.

Historical Resolution

Marx viewed stratification not as a natural or necessary feature of society but as a **historically specific product of class conflict**, which he predicted would eventually be resolved through revolutionary change.

In capitalist society, Marx identified two principal classes: the **bourgeoisie**, who own the means of production, and the **proletariat**, who must sell their labor power to survive.

References: Marx, K., & Engels, F. (1848). The Communist Manifesto. London: Communist League. · Marx, K. (1867). Capital: A Critique of Political Economy, Volume I. Hamburg: Verlag von Otto Meissner.

3. Weberian Multidimensional Theory (Max Weber)

Max Weber extended Marx's economic analysis by arguing that stratification **cannot be reduced to class (economic position) alone**. Weber identified three analytically distinct, though often overlapping, dimensions of stratification:



Class

An individual's economic position and "market situation" — their chances of acquiring income, goods, and opportunities in the marketplace.



Status (Prestige)

The amount of social honor, esteem, or respect accorded to an individual or group by others, which may not correspond directly to economic class (for example, a poorly paid but highly respected member of the clergy).



Party (Power)

The capacity of individuals or groups, often organized politically, to achieve their goals even against the resistance of others.



Weber's multidimensional model is considered more flexible than Marx's purely economic framework, since it allows for the possibility that a person may rank highly on one dimension (e.g., prestige) while ranking lower on another (e.g., class).

Reference: Weber, M. (1922/1978). Economy and Society: An Outline of Interpretive Sociology (G. Roth & C. Wittich, Eds.). Berkeley: University of California Press.

4. Symbolic Interactionist Perspective

Macro vs. Micro Analysis

Whereas functionalist and conflict theories examine stratification at the level of whole societies (**macro-level**), symbolic interactionists examine how stratification is **expressed, experienced, and reproduced** through everyday face-to-face interaction and symbols.

Veblen's Conspicuous Consumption

Thorstein Veblen's concept of "**conspicuous consumption**" describes how the wealthy display status through visible patterns of spending and leisure, thereby reinforcing social rank through everyday symbolic behavior such as dress, speech, and manners.

Reference: Veblen, T. (1899). The Theory of the Leisure Class: An Economic Study of Institutions. New York: Macmillan.

Key Mechanisms of Symbolic Stratification

Dress & Appearance

Clothing, grooming, and material goods signal social rank in everyday encounters.

Speech & Manners

Accent, vocabulary, and etiquette mark class boundaries and reproduce hierarchy.

Leisure Patterns

Visible patterns of spending and leisure reinforce social rank symbolically.

5. Lenski's Evolutionary (Synthesis) Theory

Gerhard Lenski proposed an **evolutionary theory of stratification**, arguing that the degree and rigidity of inequality in a society is closely related to its mode of subsistence and level of technological development.



Hunting-and-Gathering Societies

Display **minimal stratification** because there is little surplus to accumulate. Inequality is low and largely situational.



Agrarian Societies

With a substantial economic surplus and complex division of labor, tend to show the **sharpest inequality**. Rigid hierarchies emerge around land ownership and hereditary privilege.



Industrial Societies

Show **more variable levels of stratification**, moderated by political structures such as democratic institutions and welfare policy. Inequality is neither fixed nor eliminated.

*Reference: Lenski, G. (1966). *Power and Privilege: A Theory of Social Stratification*. New York: McGraw-Hill.*

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